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Song Sparrow

Melospiza melodia

QUICK STATS

Length	4.7 – 6.7 in (12 – 17 cm)
Wingspan	7.1 – 9.4 in (18 – 24 cm)
Weight	0.4 – 1.9 oz (11 – 53 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 3 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Song Sparrow is one of the most widespread and variable songbirds in North America, found in nearly every habitat from Alaska to Mexico. Despite its streaky brown plumage that many birders initially dismiss as "just a sparrow," it is a remarkably accomplished singer — the male begins his rich, complex song as early as February, often singing from an exposed perch even in snow and freezing temperatures. The Song Sparrow is also one of the most scientifically studied birds in the world, with research spanning over a century that has illuminated fundamental principles of ecology, behavior, and evolution.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Song Sparrow occupies an extraordinary range of habitats across North America, from the Aleutian Islands of Alaska south through Canada and across the entire continental US to central Mexico. It inhabits wetland edges, marshes, shrubby fields, forest edges, riparian thickets, coastal dunes, gardens, and suburban parks. It shows remarkable geographic variation: over 50 subspecies have been described, ranging from tiny pale desert birds to large dark subspecies in the Pacific Northwest. Many northern populations migrate south in winter, while southern and coastal populations are permanent residents.

DIET & FEEDING

- White millet — the most attractive seed at feeders
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and cracked corn
- Weed seeds: crabgrass, ragweed, smartweed, knotweed
- Insects and spiders — critical during breeding season
- Wild berries and small fruits in autumn
- Primarily forages on the ground or in low vegetation

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Song Sparrows are loosely territorial and moderately social. Males defend breeding territories through song, often countersinging with neighboring males in elaborate vocal exchanges. Outside the breeding season they become more gregarious, joining mixed sparrow flocks. They forage primarily on the ground, scratching through leaf litter with a characteristic double-scratch hop. When startled, they fly low and briefly pump their rounded tail — a distinctive behavior that helps identify them in flight. Song Sparrows show strong site fidelity, returning to the same territories year after year.

NESTING & BREEDING

Song Sparrows are among the earliest breeders in North America, with males singing on territory as early as late January in the South. The female builds a well-hidden cup nest of grasses, weeds, and bark strips, placed on the ground or low in dense vegetation. Clutches of 3–5 pale greenish eggs with brown speckles are incubated by the female for 12–14 days. Both parents feed nestlings, which fledge at 10–12 days. Song Sparrows are frequent hosts of Brown-headed Cowbird eggs — a brood parasite that lays its eggs in other birds' nests. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Song Sparrow earns its name through one of the most complex and beautiful songs of any North American sparrow. Each male learns a repertoire of 8–20 distinct song types and switches between them throughout the day. Songs typically begin with 2–3 short notes, followed by a trill and then a complex jumble of notes. The song is often described as beginning with "Maids! Maids! Maids! Pick up your teakettle-ettle-ettle." Each male's songs are slightly different, allowing individual recognition by neighbors.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The Song Sparrow population is estimated at 130 million individuals and remains broadly stable, though some regional populations have declined due to wetland loss and habitat fragmentation. It is one of the most studied birds in the world — research on Song Sparrow populations on Mandarte Island, British Columbia has been ongoing since 1975.

FEEDER TIPS

- Scatter white millet on the ground or a low platform feeder
- Dense shrubs and brush piles near feeders provide essential cover
- Song Sparrows often arrive at feeders early in the morning
- A shallow ground-level birdbath is strongly attractive to them
- Leave native grasses and weedy patches in the garden for natural foraging

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown	Brown with gray central stripe
Back & wings	Brown, heavily streaked dark
Breast & sides	White with bold brown streaks
Central breast spot	Dark brown — diagnostic dot
Supercilium (eyebrow)	Gray-white stripe above eye
Bill	Short, conical, pale gray

COLOR ME!

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